hijacked and taken to the district court where Nair had been taken by the police. The mob dispersed only after Nair was released.

Nair's preventive detention during Ratan's visit inflamed the union and the workers. There was a possibility of the labour strike spreading to the Pune–Chinchwad–Pimpri belt, a hub of more than 2,000 industrial units. The TELCO strike had also led to the formation of a federation of labour organizations in the area. The new body called the Trade Union Council (TUC) had over seventy affiliated organizations representing more than 125,000 workers.

The units in the area together had an annual turnover of Rs 3,500 crore. As the leader of the workers of the single largest industrial entity in the area, Nair held considerable sway over the council. The pressure on Ratan was immense. The political leadership was also feeling the heat.

There were several attempts at negotiations. Sharad Pawar, the chief minister of Maharashtra, attempted mediation, but the effort was unsuccessful. The lack of political support only added to the Tata management's worries. If the unrest were to spread to other units in the belt, there would be the danger of the TELCO management's concerns not getting addressed in any settlement. The wriggle room for the new chairman was limited.

On 15 March, the workers under Nair went on the rampage and assaulted over twenty personnel belonging to the managerial cadre of the auto manufacturer as well as rival trade union members in various parts of the city. TKS went on overdrive and spread rumours as well. A fake internal note, purportedly from the chairman to senior functionaries of TELCO, about the striking workers, hinting at a lockout, was exhibited on the notice board. The management was 'cornered' and Ratan was 'very aggrieved', said Prakash Telang, former managing director of the India operations of Tata Motors.

Things came to a head during the forty-fourth TELCO AGM, held on 18 August 1989 at the Birla Matushri Sabhagar in Bombay. It was the first AGM that Ratan attended as chairman of one of the biggest Tata companies, and it proved unusually challenging.

The atmosphere at Sabhagar was tense. Hordes of TELCO workers stood near the gates and doors of the building and distributed letters written by Nair to the shareholders entering the hall. Outside the compound, there was